many halls. It stood within its own inner fortifications, comprising ramparts, a surrounding moat, and gates. The treatise designates specific places for a variety of people and activities: the royal family would have slept in quarters given to each member or group. The princes and princesses, for instance, were supposed to live in quarters outside the apartments for the royal women, including presumably their mothers. The king's chamber, on the other hand, was in the centre of the palace, at a distance from the family's quarters.

The provisions for making the king's living quarters impregnable and invulnerable are many and border on the paranoid:

> He should cause to be constructed a living chamber in the centre in accordance with the procedure laid down for the treasury, or a maze-house with concealed passages in walls and in its centre a living chamber, or an underground room with its opening covered by the wooden image of a deity in a nearby sanctuary and having many subterranean passages (and) above it a palace with a stair-case concealed in a wall or having an entrance and exit through a hollow pillar as a living chamber with the floor fixed to a mechanism (and thus) capable of sinking below, in order to counteract a calamity or when a calamity is apprehended.[46]

Did Ashoka's father Bindusara occupy this sort of chamber? Were his children allowed in, to be with him? If the prescriptions of Kautilya's manual were strictly followed, the children may well have been barred entry, for certainly the queens were strongly frowned upon as entrants to his majesty's living quarters. Instead, the recommendation was for the king to visit the inner apartments ('antaragriha') of the queen favoured on a particular day, though even this was meant to happen only after the host queen was 'cleared of suspicion by old women.' If Kautilya had had his way, all palace inmates would have lived forever segregated, more or less, each limited to his or her particular quarters, mingling only when strictly necessary.

So obsessed is Kautilya with security that his injunctions could have served as the rule book for a medieval nunnery. If he had also been allowed